

Claude Code — Prompt Cheat Sheet

Modules 2 & 3 · Reusable prompts for everyday sessions

STARTING A SESSION

Orient Claude before doing anything:

```
I've never seen this project. Read the top-level files and give me a one-paragraph summary: what does it do, what language/framework, and what's the entry point?
```

Load context from CLAUDE.md:

```
Re-read CLAUDE.md and confirm what you know about this project before we start.
```

PLAN BEFORE BUILD

Ask for a plan — no code yet:

```
I want to [describe goal]. Before writing any code, read the relevant files and propose a step-by-step plan. List any risks or unknowns.
```

Refine the plan:

```
Good plan. Also add a step for [edge case]. Skip step 3 — we don't need that.
```

Approve and go:

```
That looks right. Go ahead and implement it.
```

READING & EDITING FILES

Read a file and explain it:

```
Open [filename] and explain what each section does. Flag anything brittle or unusual.
```

Edit with a diff preview:

```
Open [filename] and add [feature]. Show me the diff before applying it.
```

Bulk rename:

```
In [folder]/, rename every file starting with [old_prefix] to [new_prefix]. Show what changed.
```

REFACTORING ACROSS FILES

Grep before you touch:

```
Before making changes, show me every file and line where [name] appears — including imports, calls, and docstrings.
```

Safe rename:

```
Rename [old] to [new] in all the files you listed. Run the tests after.
```

Extract duplicated logic:

```
The CSV-reading logic is duplicated in [file_a] and [file_b]. Extract it into [utils/io.py] and update both callers.
```

GIT WORKFLOWS

Pre-commit summary:

```
Show me git status, then summarise what changed across the modified files.
```

Plan commits before making them:

```
Group these changes into 1-2 logical commits. Propose messages for each. Don't commit yet — wait for my approval.
```

Safe merge:

```
Merge [branch] into main. If there's a conflict, stop and show it to me.
```

MANAGING CONTEXT

When Claude seems confused:

```
/clear [Restate your goal in one sentence.]
```

Scope to a subfolder on large repos:

```
Only look at the files in [src/folder/]. Ignore everything else for now.
```

Golden Rules

Rule	Prompt pattern
Plan before build	"Propose a plan first. No code yet."
Grep before refactor	"Show every place X appears before touching anything."
Test after changes	"Run the tests. Tell me if anything broke."
Commit granularly	"Group into logical commits. Propose messages first."
Reset context	/clear — then restate goal in one sentence